

What Counts as Scarcity?



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Food **scarcity** means that food is less abundant or less available than would be preferred. This is a broad definition and encompasses a wide variety of outcomes for human societies. At the mild end, it simply might involve one specific food resource being scarce, while others remained abundant. At the more severe end of the spectrum, food scarcity could lead to hunger and even famine, with individuals dying of starvation. In the context of agriculture, scarcity means that yields have fallen below a minimum desired threshold. This might mean a complete failure of a crop or fields in a certain area, leading to immediate hunger and starvation. Or it might involve a low yield—low enough that stored supplies could not be replenished—leading to food scarcity in a future season or a loss of a secure food supply in a future year.

Agricultural **scarcity** is a term used by archaeologists to refer to crop yields that fall below a desired minimum threshold needed to provide immediate food supplies and, through storage, sufficient supplies for an uncertain future.

In the Gremillion textbook, you read about the multiple outcomes of food scarcity and how food shortages are managed by animals and human societies. One example of historical food scarcity, and a cultural response to that situation, is offered in the supplementary reading by Jeannette Young Norton. If you haven't yet read that document, the foreword to a cookbook from more than 100 years ago, please read it now and return when you have completed it.

The war discussed here is what we now call World War I (then referred to as the Great War). The devastation brought to western Europe is difficult for us to imagine: Years of war both destroyed crops across France, Belgium, and other countries, and also removed young men from agricultural labor across Europe and, from 1917 onward, the U.S. The threat of famine was real; Western Europe needed food and depended on imported food. The U.S., which was neutral from 1914–1917, remained an ally of France and shipped massive amounts of grain and other foodstuffs across the Atlantic. It was German U-boat attacks on U.S. transport ships in the Atlantic Ocean that finally brought the U.S. into the war in 1917.

What could housewives in the U.S. (the target audience of this cookbook) do to help win the war? According to Norton, they could cook with corn! This cookbook is held in the archives of the University of Michigan library system and comes to you as part of the historical collection of cookbooks available through the Adam Matthews Explorer, a historical collection of primary documents available for teaching and research. If you are interested, look through some of the [recipes \(https://www.foodanddrink-amdigital-co-uk.ezproxy.bu.edu/Documents/SearchDetails/UMICH_JBLCA_PB_39015094367375\)](https://www.foodanddrink-amdigital-co-uk.ezproxy.bu.edu/Documents/SearchDetails/UMICH_JBLCA_PB_39015094367375) (you will need to use your BU Kerberos login for access), which begin on page 28.

Think about the following questions based on Norton's foreword:

- Why is "Indian corn" unsuitable for hungry Europeans?
- Consider the idea that cutting back on food is a national obligation. Can you envision Americans responding to such an appeal from Congress today? Would this work in other countries?
- From an anthropological perspective, what is being asked of Americans? How would you classify this idea of changing diet and forgoing certain foods to benefit others who are hungry?
- Would this change leave archaeological traces? Would future archaeologists be able to determine why the American diet shifted during this period?